

9. Regret, Grace, and a Story Told Twice

Passage: Genesis 6:5–8, and a first look at the Flood, 6:9–9:17 (the whole Flood narrative, with its doublets marked)

A note before we begin

We ran out of time last week four verses short of the ark. Those four verses (Genesis 6:5–8) say three of the weightiest things in Genesis: that the world’s evil is *ours*; that God *regretted* making us; and — for the first time in the Bible — that someone found *grace*. Then the story of the Flood begins, and if you read it slowly you notice something strange: much of it is told twice.

Two of today’s questions have divided faithful readers for a very long time. Can God change his mind? And was Genesis written by one hand or woven from several? Neither is a test of faith, and Christians and Jews who love this book answer both in more than one way. This session lays the answers out as fairly as we can, says where the New Testament speaks, and leaves you room. Some of it may unsettle you — whether you were taught that Moses wrote every word, or have long assumed that he could not have. Either way, that is an honest response to an old and serious question, and you are in good company.

Aim of this session

Four movements: **whose fault** the world’s evil is (6:5); what it means that **God regretted** (6:6–7); **grace** named for the first time (6:8); and the Flood as **a story told twice** — the ways readers have explained its doublets. We end with a look ahead to next week, and the two other flood stories the class has already met.

Part 1 — Whose fault is it? (6:5)

*But the LORD saw that the wickedness of **humankind** had become great on the earth. **Every** inclination of the thoughts of their minds was **only evil all the time**. (Genesis 6:5)*

Where we stopped. Four verses about heavenly beings who crossed a line, and the “heroes of old” born of it. Then verse 5 changes the subject. Not *the sons of God*; not *the Nephilim*. **Humankind** — *hā’ādām*, the word of Genesis 1:27 and 2:7. When the LORD looks at the world before the flood, the wickedness he sees is ours.

We have heard this before. In the garden, both humans were asked what they had done, and both pointed away: “*The woman whom you gave me...*”; “*The serpent tricked me, and I ate*” (3:12–13). God did not dispute the facts — the serpent *had* tricked her. He still questioned each of them and sentenced each of them, the serpent included. Being deceived was real; it was not an excuse. Genesis 6 tells the same story at the scale of the world. The sons of God did cross the line, and Jude and 2 Peter say they answer for it. But the verdict on the earth falls on *humankind*.

The words leave no room. *Every inclination, only evil, all the day* — the Hebrew stacks its totals: *kol... raq... kol-hayyôm*. *Inclination* is **yēṣer**, from the potter’s verb of 2:7: the creature God *formed* is now forming things of its own. The noun appears in Genesis exactly twice. This is the first. Hold on to it.

Three answers in the centuries around Jesus

Jews in the centuries before and after Jesus explained evil in more than one way, and every answer began with Genesis. **1 Enoch** (Session 8): angels came down, seduced and taught, and their spirits became the demons — evil is done *to* us, from above. Jesus ben Sira, a Jerusalem scribe, around 180 BCE:

Say not: ‘From God is my transgression,’ / For that which He hateth made He not. / Say not: ‘(It is) He that made me to stumble,’ / For there is no need of evil men. (Ben Sira 15:11–12)

God “placed him in the hand of his Yeşer” — the yēşer of 6:5 (15:14) — and Ben Sira was an optimist about it: “If thou (so) desirest, thou canst keep the commandment” (15:15). Around 100 CE, after Rome had burned the Temple, **4 Ezra** was darker: “the first Adam, clothing himself with the evil heart, transgressed and was overcome; and likewise also all who were born of him” (3:21–22). And the rabbis, building on these two verses, taught that everyone has a **yēşer hāra**’, an evil inclination — not inherited guilt, but a pull each person must master. One midrash even counts it among the “very good” things of creation, since without it “a man would never build a house, would never marry a wife” (Genesis Rabbah 9:7, Session 5.2); the Talmud says Ezekiel called it “stone” (Sukkah 52a).

The New Testament keeps more than one of these, and lets none become an excuse. It knows the powers from above (“our struggle is not against flesh and blood, but against... the spiritual forces of evil in the heavens,” Ephesians 6:12). When it asks why I sinned, it answers in Ben Sira’s form:

Let no one say when he is tempted, “I am tempted by God,” for God cannot be tempted by evil, and he himself tempts no one. But each one is tempted when he is lured and enticed by his own desires. (James 1:13–14)

And Jesus: “from within, out of the human heart, come evil ideas” (Mark 7:21). But it does not share Ben Sira’s optimism. Paul’s answer is nearer 4 Ezra’s: “sin entered the world through one man and death through sin, and so death spread to all people because all sinned” (Romans 5:12). We are responsible, and we are not able — which is why the answer will have to be a gift.

What the flood could not wash

Now the second yēşer. When the waters are gone and Noah has offered his sacrifice, the LORD says to his heart:

*“I will never again curse the ground because of humankind, **even though the inclination of their minds is evil from childhood on.**” (8:21)*

It is the diagnosis of 6:5 again — with two words gone. *Only* and *all the time* have dropped out; even the verdict has softened. And this time it is the reason for **mercy**. The flood will wash the earth. It will not wash the human heart; that walks out of the ark with Noah. The prophets name the cure: “I will give you a new heart, and I will put a new spirit within you” (Ezekiel 36:26). And 1 Peter reads the flood itself as a picture of the washing that does reach the heart — baptism, “not the washing off of physical dirt but the pledge of a good conscience to God—through the resurrection of Jesus Christ” (3:21).

Talk about it. In the garden it was “the woman whom you gave me” and “the serpent tricked me”; in 1 Enoch, the angels. What are our versions — the way we were raised, our temperament, the culture, the devil? Some of them are true. Why does Scripture still refuse to let them be the last word?

Part 2 — “The LORD regretted” (6:6–7)

*The LORD **regretted** that he had made humankind on the earth, and he was highly offended. So the LORD said, “I will wipe humankind, whom I have created, from the face of the earth—**everything from humankind to animals, including creatures that move on the ground and birds of the air**, for I regret that I have made them.” (Genesis 6:6–7)*

Lamech’s two words from 5:29 come back here — *comfort* (*niḥam*) and *pain* (‘-š-b) — with God now their subject (last week’s handout, Part 5, traces them). Today, the first word: *regretted* — to be sorry, to relent, to change course. And here the Bible seems to argue with itself.

Scripture says both. God *niḥams* in more than thirty verses. He regrets making humankind (Genesis 6) and making Saul king (1 Samuel 15:11, 35). He *relents* over the golden calf (Exodus 32:14), over Nineveh (Jonah 3:10), and twice at Amos’s prayer (Amos 7:3, 6). And two verses say flatly that he does not: “God is not a man, that he should lie, nor a

human being, that he should change his mind” (Numbers 23:19); and 1 Samuel 15:29 — in the very chapter that twice says he regretted. The narrator holds both in one chapter. Readers have held them together in roughly five ways. Each is held by serious believers, and each has a question it has to answer.

1. Translate it gently. The Jews who put Genesis into Greek, around 250 BCE, turned *both* Hebrew verbs of verse 6 into thought: “God laid it to heart that he had made man upon the earth, and he pondered it deeply.” In verse 7 regret became anger — *ethymōthēn*, “I was angry” that I made them. The Aramaic Targum read in the synagogues kept the regret but traded the grief for a decision: “He said, (in His Word,) that He would break their strength according to His pleasure.” The question it has to answer: the Hebrew does say regret and pain.

2. God speaks our language. Philo of Alexandria, a Jewish philosopher and an older contemporary of Jesus, wrote a whole book on these verses, *That God Is Unchangeable*: Scripture speaks in two registers — “one, that God is not as a man; the other, that God is as a man.” Maimonides borrowed a rabbinic saying for it — “the Torah spoke in the language of people” — which began as Rabbi Ishmael’s answer to Rabbi Akiva about a *doubled verb* (*Sanhedrin* 64b), and read God’s pain as anger, or as humanity rebelling against his will. (Nachmanides used the same saying and kept the grief: “they rebelled, and grieved His holy spirit with their sins,” from Isaiah 63:10.) The church took Philo’s road. Augustine: “The anger of God is not a disturbing emotion of His mind, but a judgment by which punishment is inflicted upon sin” (*City of God* 15.25). The Westminster Confession calls God “without body, parts, or passions, immutable” — and in the same sentence “most loving, gracious, merciful.” Without passions never meant without love; it meant that God is never acted upon, moved against his will from outside. Calvin, who held this view, said what the figure is for:

Certainly God is not sorrowful or sad; but remains for ever like himself in his celestial and happy repose: yet, because it could not otherwise be known how great is God’s hatred and detestation of sin, therefore the Spirit accommodates himself to our capacity. (Commentary on Genesis 6:6)

— and God does it, he adds, “in order more effectually to pierce our hearts,” because he “clothes himself with our affections.” Its strength: it guards God from being like us — fickle, surprised, outmanoeuvred (“with whom there is no variation,” James 1:17). The question it has to answer: how much does the figure tell us truly about God’s heart?

3. A real grief. Others let the grief stand beside God’s foreknowledge. When a heretic asked Rabbi Yehoshua ben Korḥa how a God who knows the future could grieve, the rabbi asked whether he had rejoiced at his son’s birth, though he knew the boy would one day die (Session 8, *Genesis Rabbah* 27:4). In the same passage Rabbi Aivu hears God say: “There was regret before Me that I created an evil inclination in him” — the *yēṣer* of verse 5. In the twentieth century the Jewish theologian **Abraham Joshua Heschel** (*The Prophets*, 1962) argued that the prophets’ God has *pathos* — not a passion that overwhelms, but a concern he freely chooses, moved by what people do. Christian theologians such as Terence Fretheim and Jürgen Moltmann have said something like it. Paul writes as though he agrees: “do not grieve the Holy Spirit of God” (Ephesians 4:30). The question it has to answer: does pathos make God too much like us? (The Orthodox Jewish thinker Eliezer Berkovits answered that Heschel had gone too far.)

4. An open future. In the 1990s some evangelical theologians — Clark Pinnock, John Sanders, Gregory Boyd — read 6:6 at its most literal: God regretted because how humans would turn out had not been settled in advance. Its strength: it takes the verse at face value. The question it has to answer: the God who “announces the end from the beginning” (Isaiah 46:10). Most evangelicals reject it; the Evangelical Theological Society affirmed God’s full foreknowledge in 2001.

5. Relenting is part of who he is. The last reading is old, and many hold it together with the second, as Calvin did. Jeremiah 18 states it as God’s own rule: if a nation I threatened “stops doing wrong, I will cancel the destruction I intended”; if a nation I promised to bless turns to evil, “I will cancel the good” (18:8, 10). Joel and Jonah quote the great description of God from Exodus 34 — *gracious, compassionate, slow to anger* — and add one line: “...you are a gracious and compassionate God, slow to anger and abounding in mercy, **and one who relents concerning threatened judgment**” (Jonah 4:2; so also Joel 2:13).

On this reading God's relenting is not a crack in his constancy; it is his constancy. Every threat carries what Calvin called "*a tacit condition*" — Jonah preaches Nineveh's overthrow "*in order to prevent the overthrow.*" The Talmud hears the same in Exodus 34's doubled "*The LORD, the LORD*": "*I am He before a person sins, and I am He after a person sins and performs repentance*" (Rosh Hashanah 17b). (Robert Chisholm, the NET Bible's senior Old Testament editor, argues this view, as Tertullian did against Marcion in the second century.) *The question it has to answer:* Jeremiah and Jonah describe God relenting from what he has *threatened*. Genesis 6:6 regrets something he has already *done*.

Where the New Testament stands. Hebrews quotes Psalm 110:4 — "*The Lord has sworn and will not change his mind*" (7:21) — and speaks of God's "*unchangeable*" purpose, sealed with an oath (6:17–18). Paul says the Spirit can be grieved (Ephesians 4:30, echoing Isaiah 63:10, which uses the pain-word of Genesis 6:6). And Jesus himself looked at a synagogue full of people, "*grieved by the hardness of their hearts*" (Mark 3:5). The New Testament keeps both edges: **what God has purposed and sworn does not change, and God is not unmoved by what we do.** That does not settle Genesis 6:6 — the thing God regrets there is the thing he most plainly purposed, the making of humankind — and it sits uneasily with Calvin's "*God is not sorrowful.*" First Samuel 15 leaves the two side by side. So may we.

What it costs

Do not skip the list in verse 7: *everything from humankind to animals, including creatures that move on the ground and birds of the air*. Children drowned in this story, and animals that had done nothing. The Bible does not pretend otherwise; it argues about it. Abraham will put the question to God's face: "*Will you really sweep away the godly along with the wicked?... Will not the judge of the whole earth do what is right?*" (18:23, 25). Jonah ends with God's own pity for a city of people "*who do not know right from wrong, as well as many animals*" (4:11). Genesis gives no tidy answer. It gives a God who grieves *before* he acts, a delay in which "*God patiently waited in the days of Noah*" (1 Peter 3:20), and a promise sworn afterwards that it will never happen again.

Talk about it. Which of the five readings were you taught, if any? What would be lost if "*it pained him to his heart*" meant nothing at all — and what would be lost if it meant God had been caught by surprise? And what do you do with the children and the animals of verse 7?

Part 3 — Grace, for the first time (6:8)

*But Noah found **favor** in the sight of the LORD. (Genesis 6:8)*

Noah, נח, is *favor*, נח, spelled backward (last week's handout, Part 5), and this is the first time the word **hēn** — grace — appears in the Bible. (The *thing* is older: God looked with favor on Abel, 4:4.) Three more things.

Grace lives in the eyes of the giver. *To find favor in someone's eyes* is a Hebrew idiom used thirty-nine times, usually by someone lower before someone higher. Jacob sends herds ahead to Esau "*to find favor in your sight, my lord*" (33:8). Joseph finds favor with Potiphar (39:4). Ruth kneels before Boaz — the NET says "*Why are you so kind...?*", but the Hebrew asks, "**Why have I found favor in your eyes, that you should notice me, a foreigner?**" (Ruth 2:10). You can send gifts, work hard, kneel. You cannot make favor happen. It lives in the other person's eyes, and Ruth's *why?* is the right question.

Only once does the narrator say it of God. Moses, Gideon and David *ask* for favor in the LORD's eyes, and God tells Moses he has it. But Genesis 6:8 is the only verse in the Hebrew Bible where the storyteller simply reports it: *Noah found favor in the eyes of the LORD* — before anything else is said about Noah. Then *righteous* (6:9); then *obedient* (6:22). Genesis does not make it simple, though: in 7:1 God saves him "*for I consider you godly.*" The rabbis argued it both ways — "*it is not that he was worthy, but rather that he found favor*" (Genesis Rabbah 28:9); "*all his deeds were pleasing and sweet before Him*" (Nachmanides). In the synagogue 6:8 closes one week's reading and 6:9 opens the next. Hebrews names what Noah's righteousness rested on: he "*became an heir of the righteousness that comes by faith*" (11:7).

The same words for Mary. The Greek Bible renders *hēn* as **charis**, the New Testament's word for grace — and the angel greets Mary in Noah's idiom: "*you have found favor with God!*" (Luke 1:30).

And then at Sinai

In the rest of the Torah, the vocabulary of these four verses comes together in one place only — at the foot of Mount Sinai, after the golden calf.

- God threatens to destroy the whole people (Exodus 32:10). Moses begs him to **relent** — *niḥam* — “Then the LORD *relented*” (32:12, 14).
- Five times in six verses the conversation turns on finding **favor** in God’s sight: “you have found favor in my sight” (33:12–17).
- And the LORD proclaims his name: “The LORD, the LORD, the compassionate and **gracious** God...” (34:6) — *ḥannûn*, from *ḥēn*.
- Between them, Moses asks to be **wiped** out of God’s book in the people’s place (32:32) — *māḥâ*, the verb of 6:7. Noah never prayed for his world; Moses offers himself for his. And God refuses: “Whoever has sinned against me—that person I will wipe out of my book” (32:33). “...a man cannot rescue his brother” (Psalm 49:7).

Centuries later the rabbis read Isaiah 53:12 — “he bared his soul unto death... yet he bore the sin of many” — as Moses at that moment: “he gave himself over to death” for his people (*Sotah* 14a). The church reads the same chapter of the one who did what Moses was not allowed to do: “He himself bore our sins in his body on the tree” (1 Peter 2:24) — “the just for the unjust” (3:18), two verses before Noah’s ark (3:20). (*That last step is the Christian reading; the texts are the Bible’s and the Talmud’s.*)

Talk about it. Ruth asks Boaz *why* she has found favor. If someone asked you why God has shown you favor, what would you say — and what does it do to your answer that Genesis names grace first, and then calls Noah godly?

Part 4 — A story told twice (6:9–9:17)

Read on past verse 8 and the story starts again. A new heading — “This is the account of Noah” (6:9) — and then the reason for the flood, a second time:

The earth was ruined in the sight of God; the earth was filled with violence. God saw the earth, and indeed it was ruined, for all living creatures on the earth were sinful. So God said to Noah, “I have decided that all living creatures must die, for the earth is filled with violence because of them. Now I am about to destroy them and the earth.” (Genesis 6:11–13)

Ruined, ruined, sinful (literally ruined its way), destroy: one Hebrew verb, *šāḥat*, four times over — they ruined the earth, so God will ruin them. And “God saw the earth, and indeed it was ruined” is built on the frame of 1:31, “God saw all that he had made—and it was very good!” And it keeps happening:

	One telling	The other
God is called	the LORD (6:5–8)	God (6:9–13) — both in one verse, 7:16
Why	the heart — every inclination only evil	violence; all flesh had ruined its way
What to take	seven pairs of every kind of clean animal... two of every kind of unclean (7:2)	two of every kind... male and female (6:19–20)
The water	rain, 40 days and 40 nights (7:4, 12)	the fountains of the great deep... the floodgates of the heavens (7:11) — Genesis 1 in reverse
The clock	7 days; 40 days; 7 days; 7 days (7:4, 10; 8:6–12)	dated by Noah’s age; 150 days; a year and ten days in all (7:11, 24; 8:14)
The end	the LORD... said to himself, “I will never again...” (8:20–22)	a covenant, with a sign in the clouds (9:8–17)

What do you do with a story told twice? Three answers.

1. Two strands woven together (“J and P”)

Since the eighteenth century the Flood has been the classic case for reading the Torah as woven from sources. Take the verses that call God *the LORD* (Hebrew *YHWH* — German *Jahwe*, hence “J”), with the words and ideas that travel with them, and you have one story. Take the rest, and you have another, by the writer scholars call the **Priestly** source (“P”). Nearly every critical scholar today still divides the Flood this way, into a Priestly and a non-Priestly strand; what is debated is whether the non-Priestly strand was ever a separate, continuous source (Joel Baden says yes; many European scholars doubt there was ever a continuous “J”), and when each was written — usually the exile or after for P, though Jewish scholars such as Yehezkel Kaufmann and Jacob Milgrom argued for an earlier P.

The case is not only the names. The strands use different *words* — *a man and his mate* (7:2) against *male and female*, the phrase of Genesis 1:27 (6:19; 7:9, 16); *wipe out* against *destroy*. They have different numbers. And each lets you hear something. The LORD’s strand frames the whole flood with God’s heart: *it pained him to his heart* (6:6), *the LORD said to his heart* (8:21); it has clean animals, an altar and a God who smells the sacrifice. The Priestly strand has no sacrifice before Sinai at all; it dates everything, opens the cosmic deep of Genesis 1, grounds a law on God’s image (9:6), and ends with a covenant with “*every living creature*” and “*the earth*” — a sign in the clouds that God himself will look at “*and remember*” (9:16). Imagine hearing that in Babylon, with no temple and no king. The exiles did hear it so: “*this is like in Noah’s time, when I vowed that the waters of Noah’s flood would never again cover the earth. In the same way I have vowed that I will not be angry at you*” (Isaiah 54:9). The Anglican scholar S. R. Driver and the Presbyterian John Skinner, who set this out a century ago, were churchmen; Skinner said that pulled apart, the passages “*form two all but continuous narratives.*” And the editor who joined them kept both “*without sacrificing a scrap*” — much as the church, offered a single harmony of the four Gospels, kept all four.

Its strongest point: it faces a test it could have failed — does each strand read on its own as a story? The Priestly one does; the other mostly does. *The question it has to answer:* where a verse will not sort (7:3 and 7:9 have the “wrong” words), the theory credits the editor, and an explanation that can absorb every exception is hard to test.

2. One story, built as a mirror (chiasm)

In 1978 the evangelical scholar Gordon Wenham argued that the whole Flood is a **palistrophe** — a mirror-shaped story, like Genesis 1 in Session 2. The time periods run **7, 7, 40, 150 — 150, 40, 7, 7**, and at the exact centre stands “**But God remembered Noah**” (8:1).

	Going down		Coming up
A	Noah (6:10a)	A’	Noah (9:19)
B	Shem, Ham and Japheth (6:10b)	B’	Shem, Ham and Japheth (9:18b)
C	Ark to be built (6:14–16)	C’	Ark (9:18a)
D	Flood announced (6:17)	D’	No flood in future (9:11–17)
E	Covenant with Noah (6:18–20)	E’	Covenant with all flesh (9:8–10)
F	Food in the ark (6:21)	F’	Food outside the ark (9:1–4)
G	Command to enter the ark (7:1–3)	G’	Command to leave the ark (8:15–17)
H	7 days waiting for the flood (7:4–5)	H’	7 days waiting for the waters to go (8:12–13)
I	7 days waiting for the flood (7:7–10)	I’	7 days waiting for the waters to go (8:10–11)
J	Entry to the ark (7:11–15)	J’	Raven and dove leave the ark (8:7–9)
K	The LORD shuts Noah in (7:16)	K’	Noah opens the window (8:6b)
L	40 days of flood (7:17a)	L’	40 days — the end (8:6a)
M	Waters increase (7:17b–18)	M’	Waters go down (8:5)
N	Mountains covered (7:19–20)	N’	Mountain tops seen (8:4–5)
O	150 days the waters prevail (7:21–24)	O’	150 days the waters go down (8:3)
		P	GOD REMEMBERS NOAH (8:1)

On this reading the doublets are **the two halves of the mirror**: the story rises like the water and falls like it. Wenham added that Genesis shares seventeen features with the Mesopotamian floods, “*usually in the same order*,” though J alone has twelve and P alone ten. And Umberto Cassuto of the Hebrew University (1941) argued that the names follow the *meaning*: *God* for the Creator who rules nature, *the LORD* for God in personal relation — so the animals go in “*just as God commanded him*,” and then “*the LORD shut him in*,” which Cassuto heard as “*a father full of compassion towards his son*.” The rabbis had read the names as God’s justice and mercy long before — and added that we turn them around: “*Woe unto the wicked, as they transform [God’s] attribute of mercy into the attribute of strict justice... Fortunate are the righteous, as they transform the attribute of strict justice into the attribute of mercy*” (Genesis Rabbah 33:3). So it is the *LORD* who decrees the flood, and *God* who remembers Noah.

The question it has to answer: a mirror is easy to find when you choose which details count. Wenham grants that his two weeks of waiting are one week mentioned twice; the two 150s are one span too (7:24 and 8:3); and the seventeen shared features fit either view, since two retellings of one story combined will always hold more of it than either alone. (Wenham himself did not argue for Moses; he thought one older epic had been reworked by a priestly editor.)

3. The oldest answer: one Author, and nothing said twice for nothing

For the synagogue, and for most Christians until modern times, the Torah has one Author, through Moses — what Jesus calls “*the law of Moses*” (Luke 24:44) — and a thing said twice is said for a reason. *Two of every kind* is the minimum; the seven pairs of clean animals are for Noah’s offering (Rashi on 6:19 and 7:2). The seven days before the rain were days of mourning for Methuselah (*Sanhedrin* 108b). The rain fell gently at first, “*in order that if the people would repent, it might prove a rain of blessing*” (Rashi on 7:12). And God says *never again* twice, in 9:11 and 9:15, because *no, no* is an oath — the Talmud makes it law (*Shevuot* 36a), and Isaiah 54:9 calls it a vow. Evangelical defenders of Moses’ authorship, such as the Egyptologist Kenneth Kitchen, add that ancient writers told things as a summary followed by detail, and that the dates make one calendar of a year and ten days. *The question it has to answer*: verses that seem to look back from a later time, such as “*before any king ruled over the Israelites*” (36:31) — and strands so distinct that one twentieth-century Orthodox scholar, Rabbi Mordechai Breuer, granted them and held that God himself wrote both.

Holding them together

	The doublets are...	Strongest point	Hardest question
Two strands (Driver, Skinner, Baden; most critical scholars)	seams between two voices	each strand reads on its own; names, words and theology sort together	an editor can absorb every exception
A mirror (Cassuto, Wenham, Berman)	the two halves of one design	the whole has a shape neither part has	a mirror can be found wherever you look
One Author (the rabbis, Rashi; Kitchen)	lessons — nothing said twice for nothing	takes every word as meant, as the church and synagogue long did	later-looking verses; strands that do sort

On *who* wrote it there are really two answers: one hand, or more than one. The mirror and the tradition both read one design (though only the tradition says Moses); the first reading hears two voices and an editor who would not silence either. You may hold any of these. Whichever you hold, the story in our Bibles is the doubled one — and it is the story synagogue and church alike have read for two thousand years.

Talk about it. Read 7:16 aloud: “*Those that entered were male and female, just as God commanded him. Then the LORD shut him in.*” Does it sound to you like a seam, a mirror — or a lesson (Rashi: “*He shut the door in front of him against the waters*”)? Does anything about how you read the Flood change, depending on which?

Next week — the neighbours' floods

You have met the two other great flood stories already.

In **Session 1** we read **Atrahasis**, the Babylonian epic copied out around 1635 BCE: the gods made humankind to carry their labour, humankind multiplied, and the land grew loud. Its later version gives the reason in the god Enlil's own words: "[Concerning] their clamor I am troubled." Plague, then drought and famine — and when none of them worked, the flood.

In **Session 8** we met **Gilgamesh**, the hero who wanted a name. At the end of his epic, afraid of dying, he goes looking for the one man who survived the flood — and the survivor tells him the story. (This is the Tablet XI that, as Part 4 said, took its flood over from *Atrahasis* and still calls its hero "*Atra-hasis*.") It has a goddess who weeps for what she did:

The lady of the gods wails with her beautiful voice. / The former day is verily turned to clay. / When I spoke evil in the assembly of the gods— / O, that I spoke evil in the assembly of the gods,— / For the destruction of my people, I ordered the cataclysm. (Gilgamesh XI 118–122)

Modern editions make her the mother goddess of Session 1, who shaped humankind from clay. After the survivor's sacrifice — "*The gods like flies gathered about the sacrificer*" — she lifts a necklace of lapis flies: "*Ye gods here, I shall not forget my necklace. Upon these days I shall think, so that forever I will not forget.*" And the wise god Ea rebukes the god who sent the flood with the protest a modern reader makes: "*On the sinner place his sin; On the evil doer place his crimes.*"

Bring four questions next week. **Why does each flood come** — noise, or violence? **Who grieves, and when? Who objects to the flood, and on what grounds? And what does each god promise to remember?**

So what?

1. The flood's verdict falls on us — and the heart survives the flood. Genesis takes away the excuse ("*the serpent tricked me*"; *the angels did it*), and then shows that water cannot fix what is wrong. Jesus reads the flood as a warning about his own coming (Matthew 24:37–39); Peter reads it as a picture of the washing that does reach the heart (1 Peter 3:21).

2. God's purposes do not change; God's heart is not stone. However you read *regretted*, Scripture keeps both — and so may we, without pretending we have tidied them away.

3. Grace is in the eyes of the giver. The first time Scripture names it, the man who finds it has not yet been described — and the next people to need it are standing at Sinai, where a man offers himself in their place and is refused.

4. A story told twice asks to be read twice. However it was made, the doubling is there to be heard — and next week we hear it against the neighbours' floods.

Talk about it — to close. *First*: which is harder to hold together — that God's purpose never changes, or that our sin pains him? *Second, this week*: catch yourself once saying a version of "*the serpent tricked me.*" Then say what Genesis 6:5 says instead.
